

Tax, Tithe and Tribute

Findings from the concordagraph corpus — 151 passages, 170 connections, every reference verified against an index built from the NRSV. Warrant tiers mark how much weight the text puts behind each reading.

The central claim

The Bible does not treat taxation and tithing as two separate subjects, one sacred and one secular. It treats a fixed share of production as a contested claim, and it tracks who ends up holding land as a result. The sacred/secular sorting that most readers bring to these texts is not the sorting the texts themselves perform.

Findings

1. The same tenth, claimed by rivals

Leviticus 27:30 makes the tenth of seed and fruit holy to God. Numbers 18:21 assigns every tithe to the Levites as wages, explicitly because they hold no land. 1 Samuel 8:15 warns that the king will take a tenth of grain and vineyards and give it to his officers and courtiers. Identical fraction, rival claimants.

[text states]

The inversion is in the recipients' relationship to property. The Levitical tenth exists *because* its recipients are barred from land; it substitutes for an allotment. The royal tenth goes to courtiers who, three verses earlier, have just been given the best fields and vineyards. One tenth compensates for exclusion from property; the other compounds its concentration. **[text supports]**

This is a sharper distinction than the God-versus-Caesar framing of Matthew 22:21, which sorts by recipient and therefore by the legitimacy of authority. That sorting fails repeatedly in the corpus: Amos condemns tithes brought faithfully to a sanctuary, Malachi accuses the people of robbing God through tithes, and Ezra 7:24 records a Persian imperial decree exempting temple staff from tribute, custom and toll. Caesar's system funding God's. **[text states]**

2. Extraction, land, bondage — in three different orders

A three-step sequence recurs across three regimes, but the tax occupies a different position each time. This is the finding that a flat topical list conceals.

- **Egypt.** The land becomes Pharaoh's and the people are made slaves (Gen 47:20–21) *before* Joseph institutes the permanent fifth (47:24). The tax codifies a dispossession already complete. **[text states]**
- **Israel's own king.** Samuel lists seizure of fields (1 Sam 8:14), then the tenth (8:15), then slavery (8:17). Extraction sits in the middle, as forecast. **[text states]**

— **Persia.** The people narrate it themselves: fields pledged during famine (Neh 5:3), money borrowed against those same fields to pay the king's tax (5:4), children enslaved and fields in other hands (5:5). Here the tax is the cause. **[text states]**

Note that the Samuel case is not a foreign empire. It is Israel's own king, a domestic sovereign of the correct religion. The critique is not that the wrong god is being paid; it is that the payment concentrates holdings. **[text supports]**

3. The temple tax is the bridge

Matthew 17:24–27 is the only passage where anyone treats a religious levy as a live obligation and reasons about it. Jesus asks from whom kings take toll or tribute, concludes that the children are free, and then pays anyway to avoid giving offense. **[text states]**

It is the only node in the corpus with connections into four different groups: the imperial-tax cluster through its toll-and-tribute vocabulary, the statutory anchors through the half-shekel of Exodus 30:13, the Hebrews 7 argument, and the treasury and money-changer material. The confusion readers carry about tax and tithe is not a failure of categorisation on their part — this passage sits genuinely in the overlap, and resolves in two directions at once. **[text supports]**

4. The New Testament has almost no positive tithe instruction

Tax collectors receive seventeen passages. Tithing receives three, and all three are rebukes: the woes of Matthew 23:23 and Luke 11:42, and the Pharisee's boast in Luke 18:12. No one legislates a tenth. **[text states]**

What stands in its place is Hebrews 7 arguing the institution out of force across eight verses, landing on 7:12 — a change of priesthood requires a change of law — and Paul building a replacement with no fixed rate: weekly, proportional to earnings (1 Cor 16:2), freely decided and explicitly not under compulsion (2 Cor 9:7). **[text states]**

The practical consequence is that the modern tenth is reimposed from the Hebrew Bible past an argument that the law changed. That is a defensible position, but it is a position, not a reading. **[speculation]**

5. Both entrusted-money parables reward what the law forbids

The master in Matthew 25:27 and the nobleman in Luke 19:23 each fault a servant for not putting money in the bank to collect interest. Deuteronomy 23:19 forbids charging interest to a fellow Israelite; Leviticus 25:36–37, Exodus 22:25, Psalm 15:5 and Ezekiel 18:8 repeat the prohibition as a test of righteousness. **[text states]**

Luke 19:11 places its parable immediately after Zacchaeus, and tells us why: people expected the kingdom to appear immediately. The servant's charge in 19:22 — a harsh man taking what he did not deposit — is 1 Samuel 8 in parable form, and the parable ends with the king's enemies slaughtered in his presence (19:27). Whatever these parables commend, a straightforward endorsement of the master's economics is not available. **[text supports]**

6. Both tithe statutes sit inside chapters that price people

Leviticus 27 opens with a schedule of monetary equivalents for human beings — fifty shekels for an adult male (27:3), with the priest assessing those too poor to pay (27:8) — and only then declares the tithe holy (27:30). Numbers 18 fixes the redemption of the firstborn at five shekels (18:15–16) three verses before assigning the tithe to the Levites (18:21). **[text states]**

The valuation language runs forward: thirty shekels for a slave killed by an ox (Exod 21:32), thirty weighed out as the shepherd's wage (Zech 11:12), thirty pieces of silver for handing Jesus over (Matt 26:15) — money the treasury then refuses (Matt 27:6). **[text supports]**

Reading the tithe statutes without this frame makes them look like pure cultic instruction. In context they are one line item in a system that also prices persons. **[text supports]**

7. Every empire exempts the religious establishment

Joseph does not buy the Egyptian priests' land, because they hold a fixed allowance from Pharaoh (Gen 47:22). Artaxerxes rules it unlawful to impose tribute, custom or toll on priests, Levites, singers, doorkeepers or temple servants (Ezra 7:24). A Seleucid decree frees Jerusalem's tithes and revenues from tax (1 Macc 10:31). **[text states]**

Set against Numbers 18, where the priestly class is landless by design and funded by a transfer, the exemptions describe a different arrangement entirely: a religious establishment holding property and shielded from the levy that falls on everyone else. **[text supports]**

8. The remedy is remission, and it is consistently under-read

Deuteronomy 15:1–2 mandates remission of debts every seventh year; Leviticus 25 proclaims liberty and the return of property in the fiftieth. Nehemiah 5:10–11 enacts it — the taking of interest stopped, fields, orchards and houses restored that very day. Luke 4:18–19 announces release in jubilee vocabulary. **[text states]**

The Nehemiah chapter is usually cited for its description of the crisis. Its remedy is one paragraph further on. **[text supports]**

Where the corpus is thin

- **Babylon barely appears as a tax regime.** The corpus gives vassalage, rebellion and deportation (2 Kgs 24:1), not levies. The honest label is absence of evidence, not an inference about Babylonian practice.
- **Rome’s vocabulary is registration and lawfulness,** not economics. Augustus decrees a registration (Luke 2:1); the Gospel controversies ask whether payment is *lawful*; the trial charge is that Jesus forbade paying (Luke 23:2). The exception is 2 Macc 8:10, where tribute owed to Rome is raised by selling captives into slavery.
- **Assyrian tribute is financed by liquidating sacred property.** Menahem exacts from the wealthy (2 Kgs 15:20); Hezekiah empties the treasury and strips the temple doors (18:15–16); Jehoiakim taxes the land for Pharaoh Neco (23:35). A distinct failure mode from the land cycle, and under-represented in the graph.

Method, and what it cost

Every reference in the corpus resolves against a verse index built from the source PDF. The build script refuses to write the graph if any reference fails, any edge dangles, or any warrant tier is misspelled. That check is not decoration — it caught real errors twice.

The first indexer produced wrong citations for Matthew 17, Matthew 23 and Luke 11 — the three most important tithe passages in the New Testament — because its verse-splitter required each number to be exactly one more than the last and broke at the verses the NRSV omits from its running text. The text it returned was real; only the labels were false. That is the characteristic shape of a ghost-citation, and it is why the index exists.

One known gap: Matthew 6:12 cannot be addressed, because the Lord’s Prayer is set without inline verse numbers in the source. That node points at 6:9, which carries the whole prayer.

Standing caution

Instructions that reward associative reading — metaphor, motif, unorthodox connection — reliably manufacture connections. A fabricated *connection* is not a fabricated *fact*: every citation can be real while the link between them belongs to the reader. Warrant tiers are the only counterweight that catches this, and the speculation tier in this corpus is there to be argued with, not cited.